

HBand: Where Your Hand Becomes The Phone



Ankita K.S. is audience development editor at EFY, and secretary of IEEE-YR. She is an engineering graduate, and writes articles on technology for electronicsforu.com

Next time, when you see people talking with their hand on the ear with no phone but just a watch on the wrist, don't be bewildered, they must be using the HBand. You may ask, "How can a band or watch replace a phone?" But, HBand, with its unique concept, makes it possible to talk without a phone.

HBand is a luxury leather watch strap that is compatible with most of the smartwatches. It has a built-in Bluetooth audio fob, which compensates for the need of a phone during a call. This compact, ultra-slim Bluetooth headset is embedded in the watch strap but can be easily removed, thereby making it both audio on the wrist and headset on the wrist.

Private calling/hands-on and headset modes

HBand provides the convenience of phone call in two modes: hands-on mode and headset mode.

Mobile phones have advanced to such an extent that call features are being provided in smartwatches. So there are no issues like the phone getting lost. Surprisingly, though, none of smartwatches provides call handling in private mode. HBand completes Apple or other smartwatches by adding the private call feature that they lack, using the patented Hands-on-Talk technology.

You just have to flip open the fob and raise your hand to the ear to take the phone call. There is no need to reach for your phone and rush to pick it up. This is called hands-on mode, and is the ideal solution for a quick phone call.

If you must take a longer call, you can pull out the fob from the watch strap, insert it in your ear and use the device like a normal Bluetooth headset. This is called the headset mode.

Some HBand compatible smartwatches

- Apple Watch, 42mm and 38mm models
- Pebble watches with 22mm band support
- LG Urbane
- Moto 360-2
- Classic watches or any smartwatch with 22mm or 24mm spring bar

HBand's audio features

- Hand-to-ear private call
- Compact Bluetooth headset that docks on watch strap
- Call and voice command support
- Reads out notification and time (with an app for Android)
- High-fidelity music
- Two-hour talk time, average two-day usage
- Noise and echo cancellation
- Water-resistant speaker and mic
- Magnetic charger

The mechanism

Directional audio is fired from the bottom of the wrist, at higher volume and pressures with sufficient back volume, towards the palm of the user. When the palm is held in cupped position to the ear, it acts like a parabolic reflector, redirecting the sound to the ear.

Typically, the audio is omnidirectional. Partial directivity can be given to the audio by firing at a close range with proper openings. HBand uses normal micro speakers with suitably designed back volume, front volume and openings to provide partial directivity. This method renders partial to full private sound.

Bluetooth and the microphone

HBand uses the same technology as that of basic Bluetooth headsets. To achieve the higher volumes required for hands-on private calling, though, the amplification circuit of a basic headset is modified. A couple of hardware components are used

HBand in hands-on mode

